

14

USE OF CAN, COULD AND BE ABLE TO (IS, AM, ARE, WAS, WERE ABLE TO)

We use "**can**," "**could**," and "**be able to**" to talk about abilities and possibilities in different times: present, past, and future. Let's understand how they are used!

Present• "**Can**" and "**Is Able To**"

Use: Talk about what we can do now or in general.

Structure

- **Can:** Subject + can + base form of the verb.
- **Be Able To:** Subject + am/is/are + able to + base form of the verb.

Example

 I **can** ride a bicycle.

 She **is able to** solve difficult maths problems.

 We **can** play cricket after school.

Difference Between "Can" and "Is Able To"

- **"Can":** Used for general abilities and possibilities in everyday language.
- Example: I **can** swim. (I know how to swim.)
- **"Is Able To":** Used for specific achievements or situations, often focusing on effort or success.
- Example: She **is able to** focus on her homework even with the TV on. (Highlights effort in a situation.)

Past

• "Could" and "Was/Were Able To"

Use: Talk about what someone was able to do in the past.

Structure

- **Could:** Subject + could + base form of the verb.
- **Be Able To:** Subject + was/were + able to + base form of the verb.

Example

 I **could** read books when I was 5.

 He **was able to** finish his homework on time.

 They **could** climb trees easily when they were younger.

Difference Between "Could" and "Was/Were Able To"

- **"Could":** Describes general abilities in the past.
- Example: She **could** paint beautifully when she was 10. (General skill in the past.)
- **"Was/Were Able To":** Focuses on specific achievements or successes.
- Example: He **was able to** solve a tricky maths problem yesterday. (Specific achievement.)

Future

- **"Can," "Could," and "Will Be Able To"**
- **"Can" in Future:** Talk about things someone will **be allowed** or **be able to** do in informal situations.
 - Example: You **can** go to the park tomorrow.
- **"Could" in Future:** Used for possibilities or suggestions about the future.
 - Example: We **could** visit the museum next week.
- **"Will Be Able To":** Used for planned or certain future abilities.
 - **Structure:** Subject + will be able to + base form of the verb.
 - Example: I **will be able to** speak French after my course.

14.1

Complete the sentences by choosing the correct verb form for **present abilities**:

-  I _____ (can/could) sing very well.
-  She _____ (was able to/can) solve this riddle easily.
-  We _____ (could/is able to) complete this task today.
-  He _____ (can/was able to) play the guitar beautifully.
-  They _____ (could/is able to) swim across the pool.

 You _____ (can/was able to) ask the teacher for help.

 I _____ (am able to/could) drive my car now.

 She _____ (can/was able to) read books.

 They _____ (can/was able to) join us for dinner tonight.

 We _____ (could/is able to) play video games after school.

14.2 Complete the sentences by choosing the correct verb form for **past abilities** or **situations**:

 She _____ (could/was able to) ride a bicycle when she was 6.

 He _____ (was able to/could) complete his homework despite being tired.

 They _____ (could/was able to) play outside during their childhood.

 I _____ (was able to/could) understand the lesson yesterday.

 The dog _____ (could/was able to) find its way home.

 We _____ (could/was able to) solve the puzzle quickly.

 She _____ (was able to/could) answer the tough questions in the test.

 He _____ (could/was able to) help his friend with the project.

 They _____ (could/was able to) jump very high when they were younger.

 I _____ (was able to/could) make a new friend last year.

14.3 Complete the sentences by choosing the correct verb form for **future abilities** or **situations**:

 I _____ (can/will be able to) visit you tomorrow.

 She _____ (could/will be able to) join us for the party next week.

 They _____ (can/will be able to) travel abroad next year.

 He _____ (can/will be able to) finish his project on time.

 We _____ (could/will be able to) go to the beach if it's sunny.

 You _____ (can/will be able to) call me after 6 PM.

 I _____ (will be able to/can) learn coding by the end of this course.

 She _____ (could/will be able to) help us with the decorations.

 He _____ (will be able to/can) run faster with more training.

 They _____ (could/will be able to) win the game with better practice.

14.4 Write sentences.

 Write a sentence using "can" for present ability.

 Write a sentence using "is able to" for specific situation.

 Write a sentence using "could" for past ability.

 Write a sentence using "was able to" for specific past achievement.

 Write a sentences using "will be able to" for future plans.
